

CHAPTER 2

Tenses and Sentence Structure

Sentence patterns, tense forms, transformations, and practice

Study • Practice • Review

Prepared as a structured learning handout

1. Learning Objectives

- Identify and label core sentence components: Subject, Verb, Object, and Complement.
- Distinguish Simple, Continuous, and Perfect tenses across Present, Past, and Future timeframes.
- Construct positive, negative, and interrogative sentences correctly in basic English.

2. Basic Sentence Structure (S–V–O)

Every complete sentence in English expresses a complete thought and normally contains at least a subject and a verb. A common basic pattern is **Subject + Verb + Object (S–V–O)**.

Component	Function	Example	Sentence
Subject (S)	Performs the action or is the topic.	The teacher	The teacher explained the lesson.
Verb (V)	Shows an action or state of being.	explained	The teacher explained the lesson.
Object (O)	Receives the action.	the lesson	The teacher explained the lesson.

Sentence Complements & Modifiers

- **Subject + Verb + Indirect Object + Direct Object:** She (S) gave (V) me (IO) a pen (DO).
- **Subject + Verb + Adverbial:** They (S) arrived (V) early in the morning (Adv).

3. Understanding Verb Tenses

Tenses indicate when an action happens—Past, Present, or Future—and how the action unfolds. This chapter focuses on Simple, Continuous, and Perfect forms.

Time	Simple	Continuous	Perfect
Present	Habits / facts	Happening now or temporary	Past action linked to present
Past	Completed past event	Ongoing at a past time	Earlier than another past event
Future	Prediction / decision / future event	In progress at future time	Completed by a future time

4. Detailed Breakdown of Tenses

A. Present Tenses

1. Simple Present Tense

Use: daily routines, permanent situations, general facts, and timetables.

Structure: Subject + base verb (V1) / verb + s/es for he, she, it.

*I **walk** to school every day. • The earth **revolves** around the sun. • She **works** at a university in Kathmandu.*

2. Present Continuous Tense

Use: actions happening at the moment of speaking or temporary situations.

Structure: Subject + am/is/are + V-ing.

*Listen! The birds **are singing**. • He **is writing** his assignment right now. • We **are staying** at a hotel this week.*

3. Present Perfect Tense

Use: completed actions with a connection to the present, including experiences and recent results.

Structure: Subject + has/have + V3 (past participle).

*I **have finished** my homework. • She **has visited** Pokhara twice.*

B. Past Tenses

1. Simple Past Tense

Use: actions that started and finished at a definite time in the past.

Structure: Subject + V2 (past form).

*They **watched** a movie yesterday. • Maya **bought** a new laptop last week.*

2. Past Continuous Tense

Use: an action that was in progress at a particular time in the past.

Structure: Subject + was/were + V-ing.

*I **was studying** when the electricity went out. • The children **were playing** in the park all afternoon.*

3. Past Perfect Tense

Use: an action completed before another past action.

Structure: Subject + had + V3.

*The train **had left** before we arrived. • She **had eaten** breakfast before leaving for work.*

C. Future Tenses

1. Simple Future Tense

Use: spontaneous decisions, promises, and predictions.

Structure: Subject + will + V1.

*I **will call** you as soon as I arrive. • Scientists believe AI **will change** modern education.*

2. Future Continuous Tense

Use: an action that will be in progress at a specific future time.

Structure: Subject + will be + V-ing.

*This time tomorrow, we **will be writing** our exam.*

3. Future Perfect Tense

Use: an action that will be completed before a specified future time.

Structure: Subject + will have + V3.

*By Friday, I **will have finished** the assignment.*

5. Sentence Types: Declarative, Negative, and Interrogative

Positive	Negative	Question
She plays football.	She does not play football.	Does she play football?
They visited Kathmandu.	They did not visit Kathmandu.	Did they visit Kathmandu?

Positive	Negative	Question
You are reading.	You are not reading.	Are you reading?
He has finished.	He has not finished.	Has he finished?

6. Practice Exercises

A. Identify the exact tense:

- 1 Hari **is preparing** slides for his presentation.
- 2 We **have lived** in this city for five years.
- 3 The sun **rose** at 6:00 AM this morning.
- 4 They **will attend** the annual conference tomorrow.
- 5 She **was cooking** dinner when the guests arrived.

B. Change as directed:

- 1 "She cooks rice every day." → Negative
- 2 "They play basketball on Saturdays." → Present Continuous
- 3 "He finished his assignment." → Yes/No Question
- 4 "We will visit the museum." → Simple Past
- 5 "I am watching a movie." → Simple Present

C. Fill in the blanks:

- 1 By the time the doctor arrived, the patient _____ (already / leave).
- 2 Look! The train _____ (come) into the station.
- 3 Every morning, my father _____ (read) the newspaper before work.
- 4 Yesterday at 4 PM, I _____ (study) in the library.
- 5 Next month, our family _____ (travel) to Mustang.

7. Chapter Test

- 1 State the fundamental word order of a standard basic sentence in English.
- 2 Rewrite in Simple Past: "She writes a letter to her friend."
- 3 Convert to a negative sentence: "They were playing football yesterday."
- 4 Create a question for the answer: "He lives in Lalitpur."
- 5 Fill in: "I _____ (not / see) him since last Sunday."

8. Answer Key

Practice A: 1. Present Continuous 2. Present Perfect 3. Simple Past 4. Simple Future 5. Past Continuous.

Practice B: 1. She does not cook rice every day. 2. They are playing basketball right now. 3. Did he finish his assignment? 4. We visited the museum. 5. I watch a movie.

Practice C: 1. had already left 2. is coming 3. reads 4. was studying 5. will travel.

Test: 1. Subject + Verb + Object (S–V–O). 2. She wrote a letter to her friend. 3. They were not playing football yesterday. 4. Where does he live? 5. have not seen.

Quick Review: For questions and negatives, first look for an existing auxiliary verb. If there is none in Simple Present or Simple Past, use do/does/did and return the main verb to V1.